

day that George passes away, at least we won't be scrambling. The file should include all the steps to take before your will is probated, including tax assessments and a potential phone call to the bank. (If you have money in a joint account with your partner, you may need to notify the bank to make sure the account holder's names are separate so that your money isn't frozen in the event that one of you dies.)

Indicate where important documents can be found, such as property deeds, tax papers, insurance and medical claims. You'll probably want to keep your birth certificate, passport, social insurance number and any other official, hard-to-replace documents in a separate place for safekeeping. Safe, lockbox or safety deposit box at your bank—the choice is up to you. Just be sure to include the code or security combination in your “to be consulted on my death” file. To be extra safe, scan each of these documents so you have digital copies as well.

Write down a list of the people or entities to be notified of your death. I don't mean friends and distant relatives—though you should write those down, too—but the people who will need an official copy of the death certificate. These include: the civil authorities in your province, your financial advisor, the lawyer who drew up your will, your pension fund providers, your health insurance, other insurance companies, your various credit card providers, the office that issued your driver's license and your tax accountant (if someone else handles your taxes). List email, phone and any other available contact info for each of these people. Again, you're trying to make it as easy as possible for your grieving family members.

If you own real estate, indicate the address and expected resale value of each property. This can help your